

Briquettes from crop residue for cremation!

Do you know how much wood is needed on average to **cremate** a single body at any Hindu **funeral** ghat?

Depending on the weather, an average funeral **pyre** requires approximately 250-300 kilograms of wood. That **equates** to the wood obtained from two trees that are at least 20 years old.

Nagpur's Vijay Limaye has found a solution to this **colossal** daily consumption of wood. It is not only **sustainable** but also helps save lakhs of trees that are **felled** every year for pyre wood. The solution is **biomass** briquettes.

Turning biomass into briquettes and **pellets** is widely discussed across India, particularly because it helps reduce stubble burning and **thereby** indirectly supports India's clean energy goals. Crop residue is being burnt in almost every state, but there is a lot of attention focused on the **parali** burning in Punjab and Haryana, as it directly contributes to pollution in the Delhi-NCR region.

Vijay Limaye's **non-profit**, which works towards **eco-cremation**, **has pioneered** the use of biomass for cremation — replacing traditional wood logs with agro-waste briquettes, which he has named Mokshakashtha.

He **devised** a formula for using locally available crop residue to convert it into briquettes. His innovation helps reduce **deforestation**, **curb** carbon **emissions**, and channel agricultural residue into meaningful use.

As of July 2025, six **crematoriums** in Nagpur city (out of more than a dozen) are using briquettes for cremation. They consume an average of 1,200 tonnes of briquettes per year. "This saves 10,000 trees from being felled in Nagpur alone," Limaye said.

Only two other **cities** in Maharashtra — Mumbai and Navi Mumbai — **are** using pellet-based cremation, at nine and 12 crematoriums respectively. Limaye is **disheartened** that this concept has not gained the popularity it deserves.

"The main reason is corruption. There is a strong **lobby** of wood suppliers to the crematoriums," he says. But more than anything, it is the **absolute disregard** for environmental issues by politicians and **bureaucrats** that **angers** him. "Does saving trees not count?" he asked.

Scaling it up nationwide presents clear challenges — religious beliefs aside. There is no official **recognition** of the **practice**, and therefore no policy decisions regarding it. This in turn means there is no policy to support **localised** production and related supply chains. Citizens who might opt for it, and farmers who need to be **incentivised** not to burn crop residue, both require education and awareness. The Centre launched the Biomass Programme five years ago — a scheme to promote the manufacturing of briquettes and pellets, and biomass (non-bagasse) based **cogeneration** in industries for FY 2021-22 to 2025-26. Slowly and **steadily**, it has **taken off**, at least in the Delhi-NCR region. And **eventually**, it may spread across India.

Therefore, **perhaps** the next scheme the government needs to launch is a 'Use of Briquettes & Pellets for Cremation' programme — raising sufficient awareness and **facilitating decentralised**, local manufacturing with community participation.

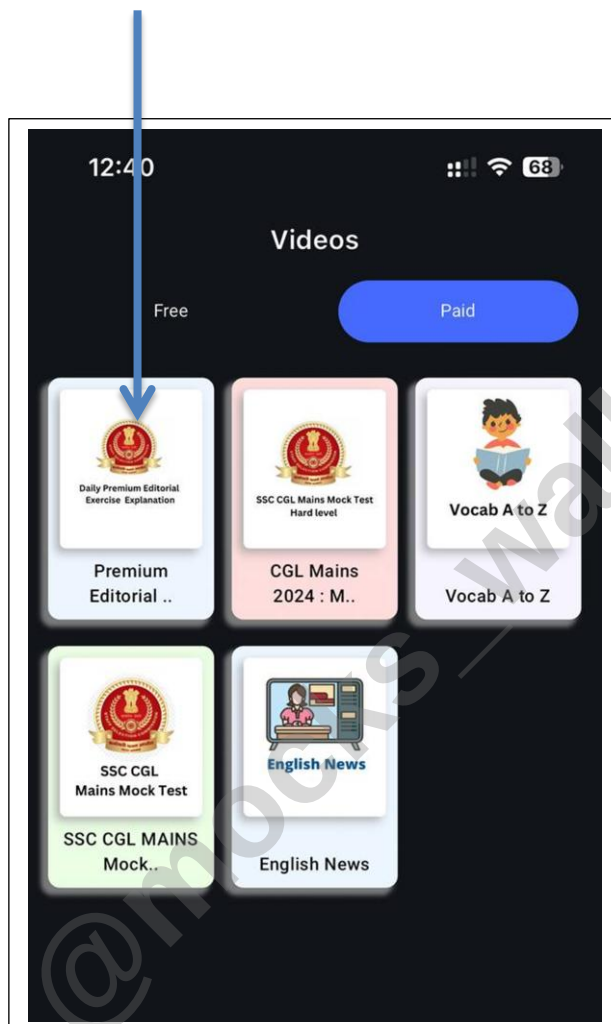
[Practice Exercise]

Vocabulary

1. **Briquette** (noun) – block, brick, compressed fuel, log, chunk ईंधन की ईंट
2. **Residue** (noun) – remains, remnants, leftover, by-product, waste अवशेष / बचा हुआ भाग
3. **Cremation** (noun) – burning (of dead body), funeral fire, incineration, last rites दाह संस्कार
4. **Cremate** (verb) – burn, incinerate, perform funeral rites, dispose (a dead body) by fire दाह संस्कार करना
5. **Funeral** (noun) – burial service, last rites, memorial, ceremony अंतिम संस्कार / शवयात्रा
6. **Pyre** (noun) – funeral pile, wood pile, burning structure for cremation चिता
7. **Equate** (verb) – compare, consider equal, relate, correspond बराबर मानना
8. **Colossal** (adjective) – huge, massive, enormous, gigantic, immense विशाल
9. **Sustainable** (adjective) – eco-friendly, viable, renewable, long-lasting, green सतत / पर्यावरण के अनुकूल
10. **Fell** (verb) – cut down, chop, bring down, knock over काटना (विशेष रूप से पेड़)
11. **Biomass** (noun) – organic matter, plant waste, biological fuel, natural fuel जैविक ईंधन
12. **Pellet** (noun) – compressed ball, fuel bit, briquette, lump गोलीनुमा ईंधन / पैलट
13. **Thereby** (adverb) – as a result, thus, hence, accordingly इस प्रकार
14. **Parali** (noun) – stubble, crop residue, farm waste फसल का अवशेष
15. **Eco-cremation** (noun) – environment-friendly cremation, green last rites पर्यावरणीय दाह संस्कार
16. **Pioneer** (verb) – initiate, lead, begin, start, introduce शुरुआत करना
17. **Devise** (verb) – invent, formulate, design, create, develop विकसित करना
18. **Deforestation** (noun) – clearing of forests, logging, tree cutting, forest removal वनों की कटाई
19. **Curb** (verb) – control, reduce, restrain, check, suppress रोकना
20. **Emission** (noun) – release, discharge, outflow, pollution output उत्सर्जन
21. **Crematorium** (noun) – funeral place, burning ground, cremation site, ghat श्मशान

22. **Disheartened** (adjective) – discouraged, disappointed, demoralized, upset
हतोत्साहित
23. **Lobby** (noun) – interest group, pressure group, influence group, faction प्रभाव डालने वाला समूह
24. **Absolute** (adjective) – complete, total, outright, utter, sheer पूर्ण
25. **Disregard** (noun) – neglect, indifference, unconcern, ignorance अनदेखी
26. **Bureaucrat** (noun) – government official, administrator, officer, civil servant नौकरशाह
27. **Anger** (verb) – enrage, infuriate, upset, annoy क्रोधित करना
28. **Scale up** (phrasal verb) – expand, increase, grow, enhance बढ़ाना
29. **Nationwide** (adverb) – across the country, nationally, all over the nation देशभर में
30. **Recognition** (noun) – acknowledgment, approval, identification, validation मान्यता
31. **Practice** (noun) – custom, method, routine, tradition प्रथा
32. **Localized** (adjective) – regional, specific to an area, restricted, limited स्थानीय
33. **Incentivise** (verb) – encourage, motivate, stimulate, reward प्रोत्साहित करना
34. **Cogeneration** (noun) – combined heat and power generation, efficient energy system संयुक्त ऊर्जा उत्पादन प्रणाली
35. **Steadily** (adverb) – gradually, progressively, continuously, consistently धीरे-धीरे
36. **Take off** (phrasal verb) – succeed, launch, rise, flourish सफल होना
37. **Eventually** (adverb) – finally, ultimately, in the end, sooner or later अंततः
38. **Perhaps** (adverb) – maybe, possibly, conceivably, potentially शायद
39. **Facilitate** (verb) – help, assist, ease, promote, support सुविधा देना
40. **Decentralised** (adjective) – distributed, non-centralized, localized, scattered विकेन्द्रित

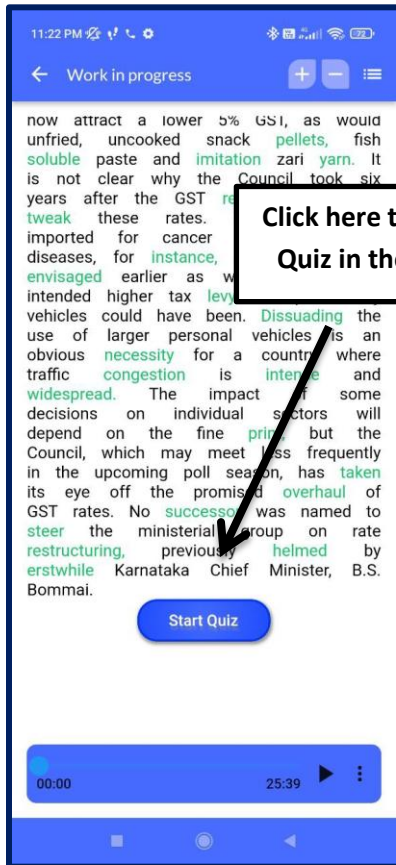
Video solution of Practice Exercise from this Editorial is exclusively available on App.



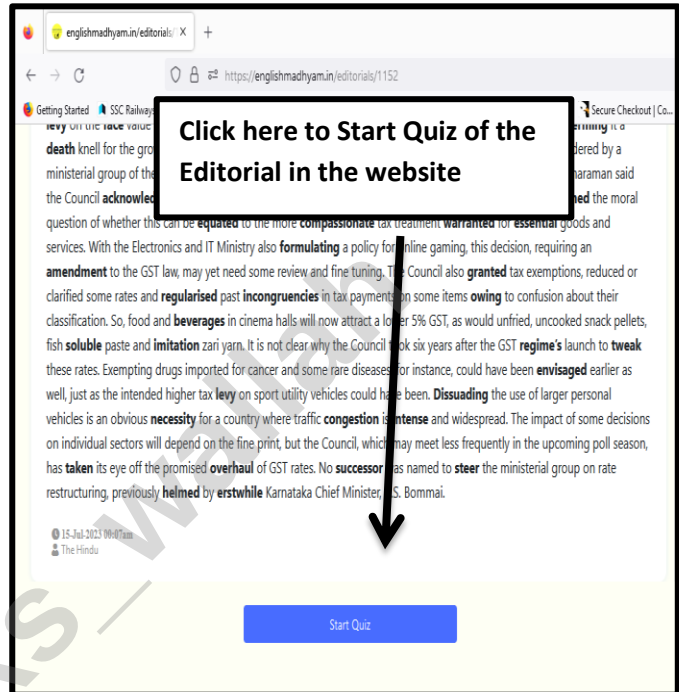
Summary of the Editorial

1. High wood consumption: A single Hindu funeral pyre requires 250–300 kg of wood, equivalent to cutting down two 20-year-old trees.
2. Environmental impact: The massive use of wood for cremation contributes significantly to deforestation and environmental degradation.
3. Sustainable solution: Vijay Limaye from Nagpur has pioneered the use of biomass briquettes made from crop residue for cremation.
4. Mokshakashtha innovation: Limaye developed a method to turn agricultural waste into eco-friendly briquettes, replacing traditional wood logs.
5. Wider relevance: Biomass briquettes can also help combat stubble burning, a major cause of pollution in states like Punjab and Haryana.
6. Pilot implementation: Six crematoriums in Nagpur are already using the briquettes, consuming 1,200 tonnes annually.
7. Environmental benefits: The switch to briquettes in Nagpur alone is saving around 10,000 trees per year.
8. Limited adoption: Only Mumbai and Navi Mumbai in Maharashtra have adopted pellet-based cremation at a few crematoriums.
9. Resistance to change: The concept faces resistance due to corruption, especially from the wood supplier lobby at crematoriums.
10. Lack of policy support: There is no official recognition or policy framework supporting biomass-based cremation.
11. Religious and cultural barriers: Religious beliefs and traditions may also hinder the acceptance of briquette cremation.
12. Awareness gap: There is a need for public education and awareness about the benefits of using biomass for cremation.
13. Existing government programme: The Biomass Programme (2021–2026) encourages briquette manufacturing for industries, but cremation use is not yet addressed.
14. Progress in Delhi-NCR: The scheme has started gaining traction in the Delhi-NCR region, showing potential for broader adoption.
15. Call for new initiative: The editorial suggests launching a dedicated 'Briquettes for Cremation' programme with policy support, local manufacturing, and community involvement.

Practice Exercise: SSC Pattern Based



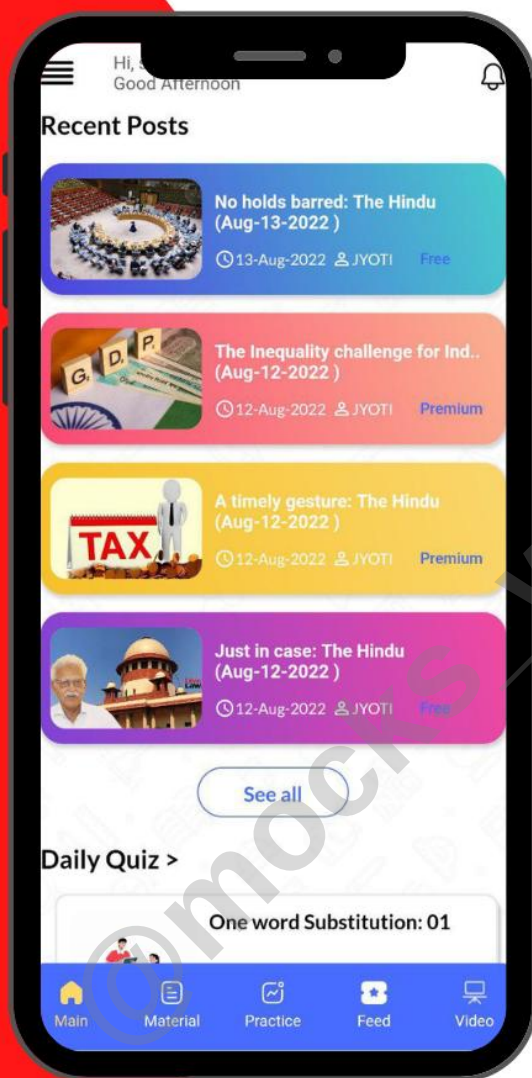
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